

1517

LUTHER TRIGGERS THE REFORMATION

In response to the sale of indulgences by the Church, the German monk and theologian Martin Luther made public his 95 Theses, which were critical of Catholic beliefs and practices. This was – in retrospect – seen as the start of the Reformation that split Christian Europe. In 1521, Luther was excommunicated by the pope, a decision confirmed by Emperor Charles V, but efforts to suppress the Reform movement failed.



△ Martin Luther posts his theses

“Here I stand;
I cannot do
otherwise;
God help me.”

MARTIN LUTHER, SPEECH, 1521

1519

1519 The Spanish conqueror Hernán Cortés leads an expedition to Mexico



1485-1547
HERNAN CORTES

A minor Spanish nobleman of exceptional ambition, Cortés became a colonist in Cuba. Landing in Mexico with a small military force in 1519, he conquered the Aztec Empire on his own initiative.

1519

HABSBURG EMPEROR ELECTED

When he was elected Holy Roman Emperor in 1519, Habsburg Charles V already ruled Spain, Austria, the Netherlands, and much of Italy. With such power in his hands, he sought to become the acknowledged head of all Christian Europe. But his dominance was contested by Protestants, opposed to his Catholicism, and by the kings of France. Charles eventually gave up his unifying project after more than 30 years of warfare.



▷ Charles V, bust by Leone Leoni

To win election as Emperor, Charles V
paid 850,000 florins in bribes